obtained?’[33]

By crossing the Indus, however, his brother had crossed a line that Akbar could not ignore. Two weeks later, on 6 February 1581, Akbar rode out of Fatehpur to war, as his father had done so often before, against his own.

. As Stephen Dale writes: Akbar ‘evolved from a twelve-year-old Timurid prince supervised by his own atabeg . . . Bairam Khan, to the triumphant status of a dominant South Asian emperor, himself a padishah in reality rather than in aspiration, as Babur had been when he assumed this title while ruling uneasily in Kabul in 1506’. See Dale, *The Muslim Empires of the Ottomans, Safavids, and Mughals* (Cambridge University Press, 2010).

. Introduction to Gulbadan Begum, *The History of Humayun (Humayun-nama)*, trans. Annette S. Beveridge (The Asiatic Society, 1902).

. Abu’l Fazl, *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl* (completed by Inayatullah), vol. 3, trans. Henry Beveridge (First published 1902–1939; Low Price Publications, 2017). Haram Begum, too, had a forbidden love. According to Abul Fazl, ‘the skirt of Haram Begam’s chastity [was stained] by insinuations about her and Haidar Ali Beg who was her beloved brother’. Ibrahim, no less ruthless than his mother, had her lover killed.

. Nizamuddin Ahmad, ‘Tabakat-i Akbari’, in *The History of India, As Told by Its Own Historians*, trans. H.M. Elliot, vol. 5 (Trübner and Co., 1873).

. Shahrukh’s father, Ibrahim, died circa 1560, and he may have married Khanim soon after Kamran’s death in October 1557. Shahrukh, then, would have been born in 1558 or later, and could not have been more than seventeen years old in 1575, when Sulaiman arrived in Fatehpur.

. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 3.

. Ibid.

. The nineteenth-century administrator J.A. Bourdillon echoed the feelings of these disgruntled chiefs when he described Bengal as a ‘hell full of good things’. See Vincent A. Smith, *Akbar the Great Mogul, 1542–1605* (Clarendon Press, 1917).

. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 3.

. Akbar did, in fact, try to tempt Sulaiman with Bengal in place of Badakhshan, but the old warlord showed little joy at news ‘of this great boon’, writes Abul Fazl. Instead, later that year, swept along by the ‘high wind of [his] passion’ for ‘revenging himself on Mirza Shahrukh’, Sulaiman left Fatehpur – apparently on the Haj, but really to seek Persian help for his quest to return home. His many Timurid relatives may have fought for the wealth and opportunities of Hindustan, but Mirza Sulaiman, consumed by ‘love for the stony land of his birth’, wasn’t interested.

. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 3.

. Ibid.

. Badauni may have counted his blessings along with the gold coins. He had almost lost the precious Ram Prasad on his way, when the elephant became stuck in a morass near Amber. ‘[T]he more it went forward, the deeper it sank in the clay. And since this was my first service of such a nature, I was in a terrible fix.’ Finally, some locals came to Badauni’s aid, telling him to pour water into the clay to help the elephant out. Fortunately, the trick worked. See Abdul Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh* (Selections from Histories), vol. 2, trans. W.H. Lowe (first published 1884–98; Atlantic Publishers and Distributors, 1990).

. Abu’l Fazl, *The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 1, trans. H. Blochmann (First published 1927; Low Price Publications, 2014).

. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 3.

. Abu’l Fazl, *The History of Akbar*, vol. 6, trans. W.M. Thackston (Murty Classical Library of India,